

FOR ART'S SAKE Shalini Gupta (right) with participants at a workshop of The Art Sanctuary in Bengaluru

HEMANT MISHRA

Colours and Camaraderie

THE ART SANCTUARY
FOUNDED: 2019
Bengaluru

***Happiness delivery:** The Art Sanctuary treasures young persons with intellectual disabilities, crafting with care artists, photographers, filmmakers and sculptors out of an abundance of natural talent*

By **AJAY SUKUMARAN**

On the rooftop terrace of a villa near Bengaluru's tech corridor in Marathahalli, an art class is in progress, where a group of young adults are engrossed in a curious endeavour—to draw and colour using their less-preferred hand. There's a great deal of bonhomie, and every once in a while someone breaks into a whoop, while others concentrate on such things as forming a heart shape. The good cheer communicates itself to the mothers accompanying them. The session is being conducted by The Art Sanctuary (TAS), a platform for 'neurodiverse' youngsters to showcase their creative skills. Neurodiverse is a term used to describe individuals with intellectual disability from conditions such as autism, Down's Syndrome, cerebral palsy or dyslexia. "Just because today we don't understand what cognitive impairment is, it cannot be brushed under the carpet," says Bengaluru-based Shalini Gupta, who set up TAS in 2019. A business consultant who gave up her career 21 years ago when her daughter Gayatri was born with Down's Syndrome, Gupta says the idea was